

Haligric Research Integration Series

FIVE PATHS OF THE LIVING WORLD

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*A Comparative Study of Naturalism, Animism, Pantheism, Panentheism, Vitalism, and the
Bengali Patua Tradition*

*"The world is alive. The sacred is here.
The story belongs to everyone."
— Five Paths of the Living World*

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Orientation

Why These Six Traditions? What They Have in Common

When you look at the history of human spiritual and philosophical thought, one of the great fault lines runs between traditions that place the divine outside the world — a creator God separate from and above creation — and traditions that place the sacred inside the world, woven through nature, life, and matter itself. The six traditions in this guide all fall on the second side of that line. None of them require a transcendent deity who stands apart from creation and judges it from above. All of them, in different ways, say that the sacred is here — in the forest, in the body, in the energy running through all living things, in the stories painted on a scroll by a traveling singer.

They differ significantly in their details — whether they are philosophical systems or spiritual practices, whether they are ancient or modern, whether they accept the supernatural or reject it entirely. But they share this foundational orientation: the world itself is where the sacred lives.

NATURALISM: The natural world is all there is. No supernatural. Science is sacred.

ANIMISM: Every rock, river, tree, and animal has a spirit. The world is alive.

PANTHEISM: God and the universe are identical. God IS nature.

PANENTHEISM: God contains the universe but also exceeds it. The universe is in God.

VITALISM: A non-physical life force animates all living things beyond mere chemistry.

BENGALI PATUA: Sacred scroll painters who honor Hindu, Muslim, and folk traditions simultaneously through painted story-songs. No walls between traditions.

Naturalism

The World Is Enough

Type: Philosophical worldview and ethical framework

Origin: Ancient Greece (pre-Socratic philosophers); systematized in the 17th-19th centuries

Key claim: The natural world is all that exists. There is no supernatural realm.

Deity: None. The universe itself may be experienced as awesome and worthy of reverence.

Followers: Hundreds of millions hold broadly naturalist views (including many atheists, agnostics, secular humanists, and scientists)

What Is Naturalism?

Naturalism is the philosophical position that everything that exists is part of the natural world — that there is no supernatural dimension, no realm beyond nature, no gods, spirits, or forces that operate outside the laws of physics. It is less a religion and more a fundamental orientation toward reality: the world we can observe, measure, and experience is the world. This does not mean naturalism is cold or spiritually empty. Some of the most profound experiences of awe, wonder, love, and meaning in human life can be understood entirely within a naturalist framework.

Types of Naturalism

METAPHYSICAL NATURALISM: The most fundamental form. Only natural things exist. There are no supernatural beings, souls, or forces.

METHODOLOGICAL NATURALISM: The working assumption of science: when investigating reality, only natural causes and explanations are considered.

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: Accepts the naturalist worldview but argues that the natural world itself — its beauty, complexity, and interconnectedness — deserves the same reverence we might otherwise give to a god. Ursula Goodenough's *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) is its most eloquent expression.

SPIRITUAL NATURALISM: The spiritual dimension of human life — awe, gratitude, ethical commitment, transcendent experiences — is real and important, but arises from and is grounded in the natural world, not a supernatural one.

Key Thinkers

DEMOCRITUS (460-370 BCE): All reality is matter and void. The first thoroughgoing naturalist in Western philosophy.

BARUCH SPINOZA (1632-1677): Argued that God and Nature are one substance (*Deus sive Natura* — God or Nature). Influenced pantheism and naturalism equally.

CHARLES DARWIN (1809-1882): Evolution by natural selection explained the diversity and complexity of life without supernatural agency.

URSULA GOODENOUGH (1943-present): Cell biologist and religious naturalist. *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998) is the most beautiful case for finding the sacred entirely within the natural world.

CARL SAGAN (1934-1996): Astronomer and humanist whose work *Cosmos* expressed profound reverence for the universe without any supernatural framework.

Connection to Haligricity

Haligricity is not purely naturalist because it works with subtle energy, chakras, and prana — concepts that go beyond what current science can measure. But it shares naturalism's reverence for the physical world as sacred in itself, its rejection of a punishing external deity, and its grounding of spiritual practice in direct lived experience.

Carl Sagan's sense of cosmic awe and Ursula Goodenough's sacred depths of nature are very much alive in Haligricity's relationship to the earth.

Animism

Everything Is Alive

Type: Spiritual worldview; the oldest known form of human religiosity

Origin: Prehistoric. Present in all indigenous cultures worldwide. The term coined by anthropologist E.B. Tylor in 1871.

Key claim: All things — animals, plants, rivers, rocks, weather, the earth itself — possess spirit, consciousness, or personhood.

Deity: No single god. Instead: spirits of place, ancestor spirits, animal spirits, plant spirits, nature spirits — an entire world alive with personhood.

Followers: Hundreds of millions across indigenous traditions worldwide. Also widely present in new age spirituality and neo-paganism.

What Is Animism?

Animism is the oldest spiritual worldview on earth. Archaeological evidence suggests it has been present in human cultures for at least 100,000 years — possibly for the entire duration of *Homo sapiens* as a species. Before any named religion existed, before any written scripture, human beings looked at the world around them and understood it as alive. The animist world is populated not just with physical things but with presences, persons, and powers. The river is not just water — it has a spirit, a personality, a way of being in relationship with the humans who depend on it. The bear is not just an animal — it is a being with its own inner life, its own relationship to the sacred, its own knowledge.

Animism Around the World

SHINTO (JAPAN): Kami (spirits) inhabit natural places — mountains, rivers, trees, and extraordinary rocks. Shrines mark places where kami presence is particularly strong. Rituals maintain right relationship between humans and the kami of their place.

ABORIGINAL DREAMTIME (AUSTRALIA): The world's oldest continuous spiritual tradition (~65,000 years). The Dreamtime is not a past time but an ever-present dimension in which ancestral beings created the landscape and continue to sustain it. Songlines — sacred routes across the landscape — map the journeys of these ancestors and must be sung to keep the world alive.

ANDEAN PACHAMAMA (SOUTH AMERICA): The earth itself (Pachamama — Earth Mother) is a living being who must be honored, fed, and thanked. The *apus* (mountain spirits) are consulted for guidance. Bolivia legally recognized the Rights of Mother Earth in 2010.

WEST AFRICAN AND DIASPORA: Yoruba, Akan, Bantu and many other traditions hold that orishas, lwa, and other spirits inhabit nature and interact with human life. These traditions became Candomblé, Vodou, Santería, and other diaspora religions in the Americas.

SIBERIAN AND CENTRAL ASIAN SHAMANISM: The shaman travels between worlds — the world of the living and the world of spirits — to retrieve healing, knowledge, and lost soul fragments.

The New Animism

Anthropologist Graham Harvey's *Animism: Respecting the Living World* (2005) marked a turning point in how animism is understood academically. Rather than dismissing it as "primitive religion," Harvey argued that animism offers a sophisticated relational ontology — a way of understanding the world as made of relationships between persons, not just objects. The new animism asks: what if the world is not made of dead matter to be used, but of living presences to be respected? What if the ecological crisis is, at its root, the consequence of treating the living world as an object rather than a community?

Connection to Haligricity

Animism is probably the tradition most deeply woven into Haligricity's DNA. The practice of sending energy to a room before entering, the idea that plants have spirits, the reverence for the earth as a living being, the offerings to animals — these are animist practices in their essence. Haligricity's earth chapter is animism applied to modern life.

Pantheism

God IS the Universe

Type: Philosophical and theological worldview

Origin: Ancient India (Upanishads, Advaita Vedanta); Ancient Greece (Stoics); systematized by Spinoza in the 17th century

Key claim: God and the universe are identical. There is no God separate from or above the cosmos. The cosmos itself IS the divine.

Deity: The universe as a whole is divine. Not a personal God who loves or judges, but the infinite totality of existence itself understood as sacred.

Followers: No formal membership. Millions hold pantheist views, including many scientists, artists, and spiritual-but-not-religious people.

What Is Pantheism?

Pantheism takes the word "God" — or the sacred, the divine, the ultimate — and says: this IS the universe. Not that God created the universe, not that God dwells within the universe, but that God and the universe are literally the same thing. Every atom, every galaxy, every living being, every moment of time is part of the divine. There is nothing that is not God. The word comes from Greek: pan (all) + theos (god). All is God. Pantheism is the philosophical equivalent of what mystics across traditions have always reported: the boundary between self and cosmos dissolves and everything is revealed as one.

Pantheism's Great Voices

BARUCH SPINOZA (Ethics, 1677): The philosopher who gave pantheism its most rigorous philosophical expression. Spinoza argued that there is only one substance in the universe — which he called God or Nature (Deus sive Natura) — and that everything that exists is a mode or expression of this one substance. The universe and God are not two things; they are one thing seen from two perspectives.

RALPH WALDO EMERSON (Nature, 1836; The Over-Soul, 1841): American Transcendentalist who described the "Over-Soul" — the universal consciousness that underlies all individual minds. "I am part or parcel of God." Nature is the face of God.

WALT WHITMAN (Leaves of Grass, 1855): "I am large, I contain multitudes." Whitman's poetry is pure pantheism — the self expanding to contain all things, all things recognized as sacred.

ALBERT EINSTEIN: "I believe in Spinoza's God who reveals himself in the orderly harmony of what exists, not in a God who concerns himself with the fates and actions of human beings."

UPANISHADIC TRADITION: Tat tvam asi — Thou art That. The individual Atman and universal Brahman are identical. This is the Indian philosophical expression of pantheism, developed independently of the Western tradition.

Connection to Haligricity

Pantheism provides Haligricity with its most direct philosophical home. The teaching that the divine lives within you — that you ARE the divine in human form — is pantheism in practice. When Haligricity holds that the universal energy runs through us and that praising the self is praising the source, that is Spinoza's insight expressed in a lived spiritual practice. Einstein's "Spinoza's God" and the Upanishads' "Thou art That" are both saying exactly what Haligricity says every morning.

Panentheism

God Contains the Universe

Type: Philosophical theology; a middle position between theism and pantheism

Origin: Term coined by philosopher Karl Krause in 1828. Developed by Alfred North Whitehead (Process Philosophy) and Charles Hartshorne.

Key claim: The universe is IN God, but God is more than the universe. God contains all that exists but also has a dimension that transcends it.

Deity: A personal or transpersonal God who is both immanent (in everything) and transcendent (beyond everything). God feels and responds to the world.

Followers: Not a distinct religion but a theological position held by many process theologians, progressive Christians, Jewish mystics (Kabbalah), and Sufi Muslims.

What Is Panentheism?

Panentheism is the position that sits between classical theism (God above and separate from the world) and pantheism (God identical with the world). The word means "all-in-God" (pan = all, en = in, theos = God). The world is in God — God contains all of creation as a body might contain its cells — but God is not exhausted by the world. God has a dimension of being that goes beyond what currently exists. Think of it this way: in pantheism, God = the universe, nothing more. In panentheism, God = the universe + more. The universe is inside God like a child inside a womb — real, alive, part of the mother, but the mother is more than the child alone.

Panentheism in Different Traditions

PROCESS THEOLOGY (WHITEHEAD, HARTSHORNE): God has two natures: the primordial nature (eternal, unlimited potential) and the consequent nature (temporal, responsive to events in the world). God lures the world toward beauty and harmony but does not coerce it.

KABBALAH (JEWISH MYSTICISM): The Ein Sof (the Infinite) contracts (tzimtzum) to make space for creation within Godself. The sefirot (divine emanations) are both inside God and the structure of creation. The mystic's task is to restore the unity of the divine sparks scattered through creation.

SUFISM (ISLAMIC MYSTICISM): Wahdat al-wujud ("unity of being") — the mystical teaching that all existence is one and that God is the only true being, with the world being God's self-manifestation. Rumi's poetry expresses this: everything is the beloved, everything is the divine wine, everything is the ocean.

DEEP ECOLOGY: The philosophical movement that extends moral consideration to all living things and to ecosystems as wholes. Panentheism provides the theological grounding for this view.

Connection to Haligrigity

Panentheism adds something to Haligrigity that pure pantheism doesn't: the sense that the divine is both fully present in us AND points toward something more — toward an infinite that exceeds what we can currently experience or understand. When Haligrigity writes about "the field of infinite possibilities" and about deities as real energies we can honor without worshipping, that is panentheistic. The deities are real aspects of the divine wholeness that contains us.

Vitalism

Life Force Is Real

Type: Philosophical and scientific position; also a basis for many healing traditions

Origin: Ancient in all cultures (prana, qi, pneuma, mana, orenda). Systematized in Western philosophy by Aristotle's concept of "psyche" and in 18th-19th century Romantic science.

Key claim: Living organisms are fundamentally different from non-living matter. Life is animated by a non-physical force, energy, or principle that cannot be reduced to chemistry and physics alone.

Followers: Not a religion with formal membership. Present in Ayurveda, Traditional Chinese Medicine, Reiki, homeopathy, and most energy healing traditions.

What Is Vitalism?

Vitalism is the idea that life cannot be fully explained by physics and chemistry alone — that living beings are animated by something more than the sum of their molecules. Different traditions have given this "something more" different names: prana in Sanskrit, qi or chi in Chinese, pneuma in Greek, mana in Polynesian, orenda in Iroquois, and many others. But the underlying intuition is strikingly consistent across cultures and across history: living things carry a force, an energy, a principle of vitality that distinguishes them from dead matter.

Vitalism Across Traditions

AYURVEDA (INDIAN) — PRANA: The life force that flows through the body's nadis (channels) and is regulated through breath (pranayama), diet, herbs, and lifestyle. Health = prana flowing freely. Disease = prana blocked, deficient, or excessive.

TRADITIONAL CHINESE MEDICINE — QI (CHI): The fundamental substance and force of all life. Flows through meridians. Balanced by yin and yang principles. Regulated through acupuncture, herbs, qigong, tai chi, and dietary practices.

REIKI — KI / UNIVERSAL LIFE ENERGY: The universal life energy that the Reiki practitioner channels through their hands for healing. Not generated by the practitioner — drawn from the infinite field of universal energy that permeates all existence.

ANTHROPOSOPHY (RUDOLF STEINER) — ETHERIC BODY: Steiner described four bodies: the physical, etheric (life force), astral (soul), and ego. The etheric body is the vitalist principle — the formative force that organizes matter into living form.

Vitalism and Modern Science

Classical vitalism was largely displaced by molecular biology in the 20th century — the discovery of DNA and the mechanisms of cellular life seemed to explain life without needing any special force. But the picture is more complex now. Fields like bioelectricity (Michael Levin's work at Tufts showing that electrical fields guide biological form), quantum effects in photosynthesis and bird navigation, and the hard problem of consciousness all point to dimensions of life that purely mechanical models struggle to capture. Vitalism may be wrong in its classical form and right in its intuition.

Connection to Haligricity

Vitalism is the philosophical backbone of Haligricity's energy practices. When practitioners run the heaven-earth current, work with chakras, practice pranayama, or use Reiki, they are working with the vitalist reality of life force. Haligricity aligns with Traditional Chinese Medicine's qi and Ayurveda's prana as its primary frameworks for understanding and working with this force. We do not need to resolve the scientific debate to experience the results.

The Bengali Patua Tradition

Sacred Scrolls and Singing Stories

Type: Living hereditary tradition of sacred scroll painting and story-singing

Origin: West Bengal and Bangladesh, India. Ancient roots; documented continuously from at least the medieval period.

Key figures: The Patua — a hereditary community of artist-storytellers. Both Hindu and Muslim Patua families practice the tradition.

What they make: Pata (scrolls) — long, accordion-folded painted narratives depicting sacred stories from Hindu mythology, Islamic tradition, folk tales, and contemporary events.

What they do: The Chitrakar (picture-maker) unrolls the scroll panel by panel while singing the story it depicts — a total art form combining painting, poetry, music, and sacred narrative.

Sacred to whom? To everyone. Patua artists have historically served both Hindu and Muslim communities, painting stories from both traditions without belonging exclusively to either.

The World of the Patua

Imagine a traveler arriving at a village in Bengal. On their back they carry a long rolled scroll — their pata, their picture-story. They unroll it in the village square, panel by panel, and as each panel is revealed they begin to sing. The painting and the song tell the same story simultaneously — the visual and the musical moving together. The villagers gather. Some have heard the story before; some are hearing it for the first time. Either way, the scroll is the scripture and the song is the prayer. This is the world of the Patua — the Bengali scroll-painter storytellers who have carried the sacred stories of the subcontinent from village to village for centuries. They are artists, musicians, historians, spiritual counselors, and community memory keepers all at once.

What Makes the Patua Tradition Unique

NO WALLS BETWEEN TRADITIONS: Patua families are both Hindu and Muslim, and both communities' artists paint stories from both traditions without apparent contradiction. A Muslim Patua paints Durga defeating Mahisha. A Hindu Patua paints the Prophet Muhammad's Night Journey (without depicting the Prophet's face, following Islamic convention). The sacred stories of humanity belong to humanity — not to any one group.

THE SCROLL AS LIVING SCRIPTURE: Unlike a fixed sacred text, the pata is a living object that the artist makes, owns, carries, sings, and eventually replaces. It is not preserved behind glass in a library — it is used, worn, loved, and renewed. The sacred lives in the making and the singing, not in the object alone.

STORY AS THE VEHICLE OF TRUTH: The Patua do not argue theology. They tell stories. The Ramayana, the Mahabharata, the life of the Prophet, the story of Manasa the snake goddess, contemporary stories of disaster and social justice — all are told in the same visual and musical language.

SOCIAL FUNCTION AND HEALING: Traditionally, the Patua were called to villages after calamities — floods, epidemics, conflict — to tell the story of what happened and weave it into the larger fabric of meaning that the community shared. This continues in contemporary Patua work, which now addresses AIDS awareness, COVID, climate change, and social violence.

The Patua Today

Naya village in Pingla subdivision of West Bengal's Paschim Medinipur district is home to around 100 Patua families whose artistry has gained global attention. Naya's Patua artists have exhibited in galleries in the USA, Germany, Australia, France, Britain,

Sweden, and China. With support from the NGO Banglanatak and the cooperative CHITRATARU, the tradition has experienced a sustained revival since the 1990s. Many Patua from the village have won India's President's Award. Contemporary Patua scrolls address female infanticide, communal violence, environmental destruction, and pandemic in the ancient visual language — applying centuries-old craft to the crises of the present.

"We paint what we see and sing what we paint. The scroll is our book and the song is how we read it aloud." — Traditional Patua artist, West Bengal

Connection to Haligrity

The Bengali Patua tradition is the most direct ancestor of the spirit of Haligrity among all six traditions in this guide. Its refusal to put walls between sacred traditions, its use of beauty (visual art and song) as the vehicle of truth, its rootedness in community healing, its contemporary relevance — all of these are core to what Haligrity is building. The Patua shows us that a path can honor Hindu, Islamic, Buddhist, and folk traditions simultaneously without collapsing into incoherence. It does so through art, story, and song — the oldest human technologies for carrying the sacred across generations.

Comparison and Connection

The Shared Core

Despite their significant differences, all six traditions converge on a set of foundational orientations that distinguish them sharply from the dominant Abrahamic framework of a transcendent creator God:

THE SACRED IS HERE: In the world, in the body, in the living present — not in a separate supernatural realm to be accessed only after death or through priestly intermediaries.

THE WORLD DESERVES REVERENCE: Whether it is called God (pantheism), spirit (animism), life force (vitalism), or simply nature (naturalism), the physical world is not mere backdrop for human drama — it is sacred in itself.

HUMAN BEINGS ARE CONTINUOUS WITH EXISTENCE: Not fallen creatures awaiting rescue. Expressions of the same reality that makes the stars, the soil, and the sparrow.

DIRECT EXPERIENCE IS THE PRIMARY AUTHORITY: Not scripture alone, not institutional hierarchy — the lived encounter with the sacred in nature, in energy, in relationship, in story.

MULTIPLICITY IS REAL: No single story captures all of truth. The Patua's practice of honoring many traditions simultaneously is the most explicit version of what all these traditions imply.

Where They Diverge

The Key Differences

THE SUPERNATURAL: Naturalism rejects it entirely. Animism, vitalism, and the Patua tradition work freely with it. Pantheism and panentheism redefine it rather than accept or reject it.

PERSONAL VS. IMPERSONAL SACRED: Animism has the most personal sacred — individual spirits with personalities and preferences. Naturalism has the most impersonal — no personhood beyond the physical. Pantheism tends toward an impersonal absolute; panentheism toward a relational personal God.

THE ROLE OF SCIENCE: Naturalism is the most science-aligned. Vitalism is the most in tension with mainstream science. The others are largely science-compatible while adding dimensions science doesn't address.

HUMAN UNIQUENESS: Animism most radically decenters the human — we are one being among many, not the crown of creation. Pantheism and panentheism often maintain a special role for consciousness. Naturalism situates humans firmly within the animal kingdom.

PRACTICES AND COMMUNITY: The Patua tradition has the most concrete, embodied community practice — the scroll, the song, the village gathering. Naturalism has the least formalized practice. Animism has the most geographically specific practice — tied to particular places, spirits, and ceremonies.

Each Tradition and Science

NATURALISM: Identical to the scientific worldview applied broadly. No areas of tension — naturalism accepts all scientific findings.

ANIMISM: Pre-scientific but not anti-scientific. Compatible once understood as a relational ontology rather than a literal claim about spirits as physical entities. Spirit personhood of rocks and rivers is not scientifically verifiable but is not falsified by science either.

PANTHEISM: Highly compatible — Einstein was a pantheist. Science reveals the divine nature of the cosmos. The equation $\text{God} = \text{universe}$ is philosophical, not empirical.

PANENTHEISM: Compatible — Process theology embraces evolution and cosmology. God experiences the world through its processes. The "more than" — the transcendent dimension — is not empirically accessible but not falsified.

VITALISM: Most in tension. Classical vitalism was displaced by molecular biology. But quantum biology (bioelectricity, quantum photosynthesis) and the hard problem of consciousness create genuine unresolved edges. Life force as experienced may be real even if not yet measurable.

BENGALI PATUA: Not concerned with scientific validation — entirely different domain. Story, art, and healing do not require scientific proof. No significant tension — different questions entirely.

How Each Tradition Relates to Haligrlicity

HALIGRICITY AND NATURALISM: Haligrlicity shares naturalism's reverence for the earth as sacred in itself, its grounding of practice in direct experience, and its freedom from a punishing external deity. It goes beyond naturalism in working with subtle energy, chakras, and spirit. Haligrlicity is not naturalist but is deeply nature-reverent.

HALIGRICITY AND ANIMISM: The deepest ancestor. Haligrlicity's earth stewardship, offerings to animals, plant meditation, energy of place, and sending energy ahead into spaces are all animist practices. The understanding that the earth is alive and that we are in relationship with — not just on top of — the living world is animism's core gift to Haligrlicity.

HALIGRICITY AND PANTHEISM: The philosophical spine. The central teaching that the divine lives within you and that caring for yourself is an act of reverence — is pantheism in practice. You are not separate from the divine and working to get back to it. You ARE it, in one of its infinite forms.

HALIGRICITY AND PANENTHEISM: Panentheism gives Haligrlicity the capacity to honor deities (as real aspects of the divine totality that contains us) without reducing the divine to any one form. It also gives the sense of infinite possibility — the field of infinite possibilities that Haligrlicity describes is the panentheist's "more than" — the divine exceeding what currently exists.

HALIGRICITY AND VITALISM: Haligrlicity's entire energy practice rests on vitalist foundations. Prana, qi, chakras, meridians, Reiki, qigong, pranayama — all of these are vitalist technologies. Haligrlicity works with life force as real, present, and trainable.

HALIGRICITY AND THE BENGALI PATUA: The Patua is the spirit of Haligrlicity made visible. No walls between traditions. All sacred stories honored. Beauty as the vehicle of truth. Art and song as healing. Community storytelling as sacred practice. If Haligrlicity had an ancestor it would point to most proudly, it might be the traveling scroll-singer arriving at a village, unrolling their pata, and beginning to sing a story that belongs to everyone.

Could Any of These Name Our Path?

NATURALISM: Too limiting. Haligrlicity works with subtle energy, chakras, and spirit that naturalism would exclude. Calling the path "Naturalist" would immediately create a false picture.

ANIMISM: Close in spirit but carries cultural weight. "Animism" belongs primarily to indigenous traditions and using it as the name for a new path risks cultural appropriation. Better to honor animism as an influence.

PANTHEISM: Philosophically the best fit for Haligrlicity's core theology. But "Pantheism" sounds more like a philosophical position than a lived spiritual path.

PANENTHEISM: Even more accurate philosophically but even less accessible as a name. Most people have never heard the word.

VITALISM: Names the energy practice perfectly but misses the earth, the story, the community, and the broader philosophy.

PATUA-INSPIRED NAMING: The most interesting possibility. A name that carries the Patua spirit — inter-traditional, story-centered, beauty-as-truth — without claiming to BE the Patua tradition. Words like "Chitrakar" (picture-maker), "Pata" (the living scroll), or "Sangit" (the sacred song) could inspire something original.

A thought on naming: the right name for Haligrlicity will probably not come from any of these six traditions directly. It will be coined — a new word that carries the energy of what this path actually is. The Patua tradition is a reminder that the most powerful sacred things are often not named at all — they are simply done, sung, painted, and lived. The name will arrive when the practice is clear enough.

Appendix

Key Thinkers and Their Works

NATURALISM

Ursula Goodenough — *The Sacred Depths of Nature* (1998): The most beautiful case for religious naturalism. A cell biologist finds the sacred in the deep story of life.

Carl Sagan — *Cosmos* (1980); *Pale Blue Dot* (1994): Profound reverence for the cosmos without supernatural framing.

John Dewey — *A Common Faith* (1934): Naturalistic humanism. Religious experience without supernatural religion.

ANIMISM

Graham Harvey — *Animism: Respecting the Living World* (2005): The definitive contemporary academic treatment. Reframes animism as sophisticated relational ontology, not "primitive religion."

Robin Wall Kimmerer — *Braiding Sweetgrass* (2013): Potawatomi botanist weaving indigenous animist wisdom with Western science. One of the most important ecological and spiritual books of the 21st century.

PANTHEISM

Baruch Spinoza — *Ethics* (1677): The philosophical foundation of pantheism. Dense but world-changing.

Ralph Waldo Emerson — *Nature* (1836); *Essays: First Series* (1841): American Transcendentalist pantheism in accessible, beautiful prose.

PANENTHEISM

Alfred North Whitehead — *Process and Reality* (1929): Difficult but foundational. The universe as process; God as the creative advance into novelty.

Matthew Fox — *Original Blessing* (1983): Process theology meets Christian mysticism. Creation as blessing.

VITALISM

Mantak Chia — *Awaken Healing Energy Through the Tao* (1983): Practical Taoist vitalism. The Inner Smile. Microcosmic orbit.

Michael Levin — Research on bioelectricity at Tufts University (2010-present): Cutting-edge science on how electrical fields guide biological form. The closest thing to scientific vitalism in mainstream biology.

BENGALI PATUA

Minu Chitrakar — Contemporary Patua master, Naya village, West Bengal: One of the most celebrated living Patua artists. Her work addresses contemporary social issues in the traditional scroll format.

Glossary

ANIMISM: The worldview that all things — animals, plants, rivers, rocks — possess spirit, consciousness, or personhood.

CHITRAKAR: Sanskrit/Bengali: "picture-maker." The Patua artist-storyteller who paints pata scrolls and sings their stories in performance.

DEUS SIVE NATURA: Latin: "God or Nature." Spinoza's equation of God and the natural universe — the foundation of philosophical pantheism.

EIN SOF: Hebrew: "The Infinite." In Kabbalah, the limitless aspect of God that contracts to make space for creation within Godself.

KAMI: Japanese: spirits or sacred presences that inhabit natural places, objects, and phenomena in Shinto tradition.

NEW ANIMISM: Contemporary academic and spiritual reframing of animism as a sophisticated relational ontology, not "primitive religion."

PANENTHEISM: The theological position that the universe is IN God but God exceeds the universe. Pan (all) + en (in) + theos (God).

PANTHEISM: The philosophical position that God and the universe are identical. Pan (all) + theos (God). God IS nature, and nature IS God.

PATA / PATA CHITRA: Bengali/Sanskrit: the accordion-folded painted scroll of the Patua tradition. "Pata chitra" = scroll picture.

PATUA: The hereditary community of Bengali scroll painters and storytellers.

PROCESS THEOLOGY: Panentheist theology based on Alfred North Whitehead's process philosophy. God is dipolar: primordial (eternal possibility) and consequent (responsive to the world).

RELIGIOUS NATURALISM: The position that the natural world itself deserves the reverence traditionally given to God — without supernaturalism.

SONGLINES: Sacred routes across the Australian landscape corresponding to the journeys of Aboriginal ancestral beings. Must be sung to maintain the world.

VITALISM: The philosophical position that living organisms are animated by a non-physical life force (prana, qi, pneuma, mana) beyond what chemistry alone can explain.

"The world is alive. The sacred is here. The story belongs to everyone."

Six paths, all pointing the same direction: toward a world that is not dead matter waiting to be used but a living community of presences worthy of reverence. The Naturalist finds the sacred in the deep story of life itself. The Animist knows that every river has a name and every mountain has a personality. The Pantheist recognizes the cosmos as the face of

God. The Panentheist holds space for a divine that contains everything and exceeds everything. The Vitalist works with the current that makes the difference between alive and not-alive. And the Patua sings a story that belongs to no one tradition and therefore belongs to everyone. Grand Rising.